

A Vandal horseman hunts a stag.

A Barbary stag, a type of red deer found in North Africa



▲ VANDALS IN AFRICA

In 429 CE, the Vandals crossed into Africa and founded a kingdom that included Sicily, Malta, Sardinia, and Corsica. In 455 CE, they sacked Rome, which is why “vandalism” now means deliberate destruction. Despite this, wealthy Vandals in Africa lived like Romans, in villas decorated with mosaics (above).

Germanic peoples

The first Germanic peoples came from modern-day Scandinavia and were probably driven south by climate change. By the 3rd century BCE, many tribes had settled in the area east of the Rhine River and north of the Danube River. The Romans called this region Germania, and tried several times to conquer it but failed. For several centuries the two cultures lived alongside each other in relative peace.

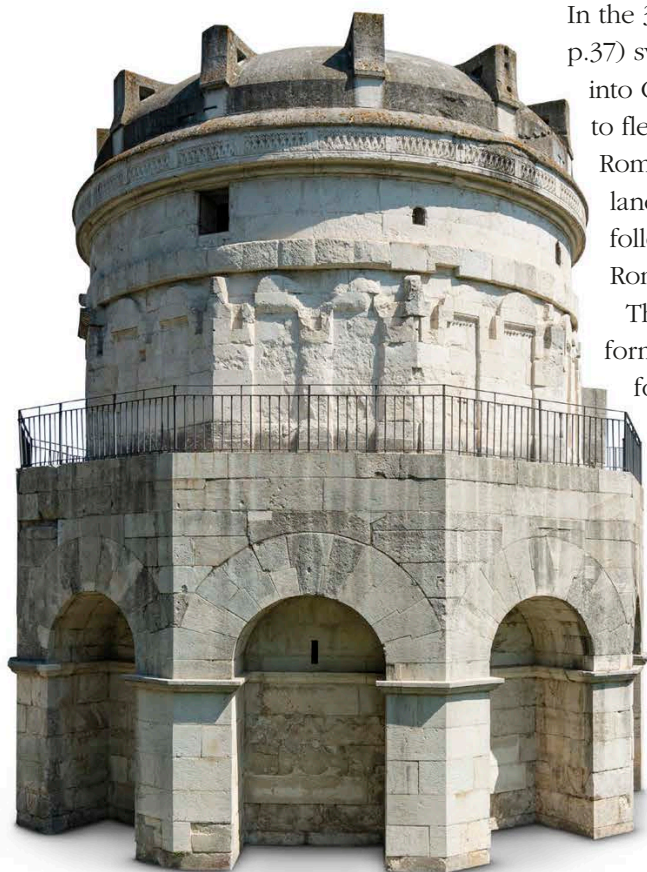
In the 370s CE, the nomadic Huns (see p.37) swept west from Central Asia into Germania, forcing several tribes to flee further west into the Western Roman Empire in search of new lands to settle. A series of wars followed and in 476 CE the Western Roman Empire fell.

The Germanic peoples formed new kingdoms across the former empire—the Visigoths in Gaul and modern-day Spain, the Ostrogoths in Italy, the Vandals in North Africa, the Angles and Saxons in Britain, and the Franks in Gaul.

These Germanic peoples wanted to exploit the wealth of the former Roman Empire rather than plunder it. Influenced by Roman culture, kings modeled themselves on Roman emperors. They became Christians, though many continued to worship Germanic gods. Most adopted new languages based on Latin, though in remote Britain the Anglo-Saxon kingdoms kept their language, which developed into English. Over the next 300 years, some of these Germanic kingdoms would grow into the major powers of medieval Europe.

◀ OSTROGOTHS IN ITALY

The Ostrogoths, or eastern Goths, built up an empire that stretched north of the Black Sea in eastern Europe. In 493 CE, led by Theodoric the Great, they conquered modern-day Italy and established the Ostrogothic Kingdom. The empire reached its peak under the rule of Theodoric the Great who was buried in a grand mausoleum (left) at Ravenna, Italy. After his death, the Ostrogoths suffered repeated invasions by the Byzantine Empire, resulting in their decline.



THEODORIC THE GREAT

The most powerful Germanic king was Theodoric the Great (reigned 493–526 CE). From 511 CE, he ruled both the Ostrogoths and the Visigoths, governing a kingdom that stretched from modern-day Spain to Italy.



COIN DEPICTING THEODORIC